

Squeeze the cell phone

Saying it with a nice comforting vibration could well be the next way to communicate. MIT Media Lab is working on letting people communicate by passing along the 'touch' element. The Tangible Media Group, the research team at the Media Lab, says that the existing vibrator mode is too crude to actually convey subtle feelings. Hence they have come up with a proto-



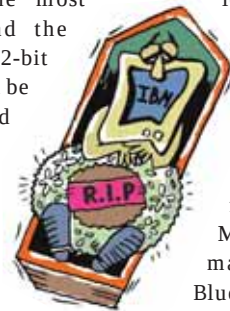
type design that features five tiny speakers that vibrate against the skin on the fingers and thumbs some 250 times per second.

Pressure sensors tucked behind the speakers let you vibrate the person right back. The intensity of the vibration depends upon how hard you squeeze. When test-

ing this on a group of students, they immediately used the technique to emphasise what they were saying, or to interrupt the other person. Over time, they managed to develop a distinct 'vibrallanguage' that added to the effect of talking on the cell phone. All the users found it extremely easy to work with and to get used to this. The idea is to let people transmit thoughts and feelings more effectively and also help people with disabilities communicate using cell phones.

Who killed OS/2?

OS/2, one of the most robust OSes and the world's first fully 32-bit graphical desktop will be declared officially dead by IBM on March 12, 2003, with support continued till December 31, 2004. IBM's support is considered an industry standard and their commitment to older technology is



legendary. Still, the move comes as no surprise—with IBM's inability to attract the hardware community to write drivers for newer devices, Microsoft stole a march right under Big Blue's nose by getting hardware support for Windows 95 right from its launch.

Block viruses

With computer viruses spreading through networks faster than the eye can blink, a researcher at the Hewlett-Packard laboratories in England just came up with a radical new theory—put the brakes on the infected computer to limit infection. Computers that are infected tend to behave differently than uninfected ones, says Matthew Williamson, the HP researcher.

The infected computer quickly tries to make as many connections as possible with neighbouring computers, through all possible network services, including e-mail. Throttling back the infected computer results in it taking a far longer time to start infecting other machines, giving enough time to alert system administrators to take necessary actions.

The idea worked amazingly well at HP's lab, during tests to try out this new theory. Incidentally, the limits imposed by throttling appeared to have no noticeable impact to the user of the infected computers.

redalert

Drive eraser

W32.Galil@mm is a mass-mailing worm that has the potential to overwrite all files on all drives that it can write to with 215 bytes of text. It is written in Visual Basic and its uncompressed size is 80,626 bytes.

The worm uses its own SMTP engine or Microsoft Outlook to send itself to all addresses that it finds on the infected computer. Multiple copies of the worm can be attached to the outgoing message. The message seems to have been forwarded from a Yahoo! account and talks about sex being illegal in the United States.

The latest virus definitions of most anti-virus software should take care of the worm.

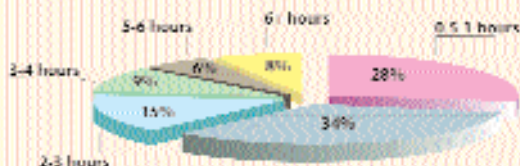
P2P Worm

This is a memory-resident worm called AGOBOT.C and it propagates itself through the KaZaa, Grokster and Bearshare file-sharing peer-to-peer networks and network shared drives. It regularly attempts to connect to an Internet Relay Chat (IRC) server as a bot. When connected, it may launch Denial of Service (DoS) attacks against other users. It also has backdoor capabilities and allows malicious users to take control of infected PCs.

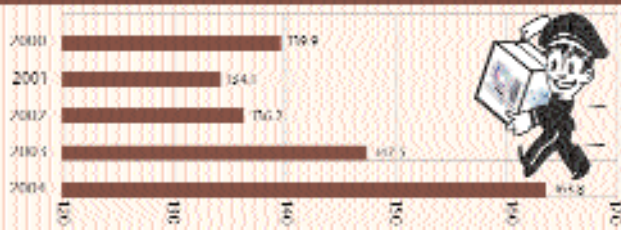
This worm infects all computers running on Windows and creates entries in the registry so that it runs automatically every time Windows starts. It can be identified and removed with the latest updates of most anti-virus software such as AVG or Norton AntiVirus.

statattack

Hours spent by IT professionals on internet research



PC shipment projections



Source: IDC

INFOGRAPHICS: Sachin Dalvi

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